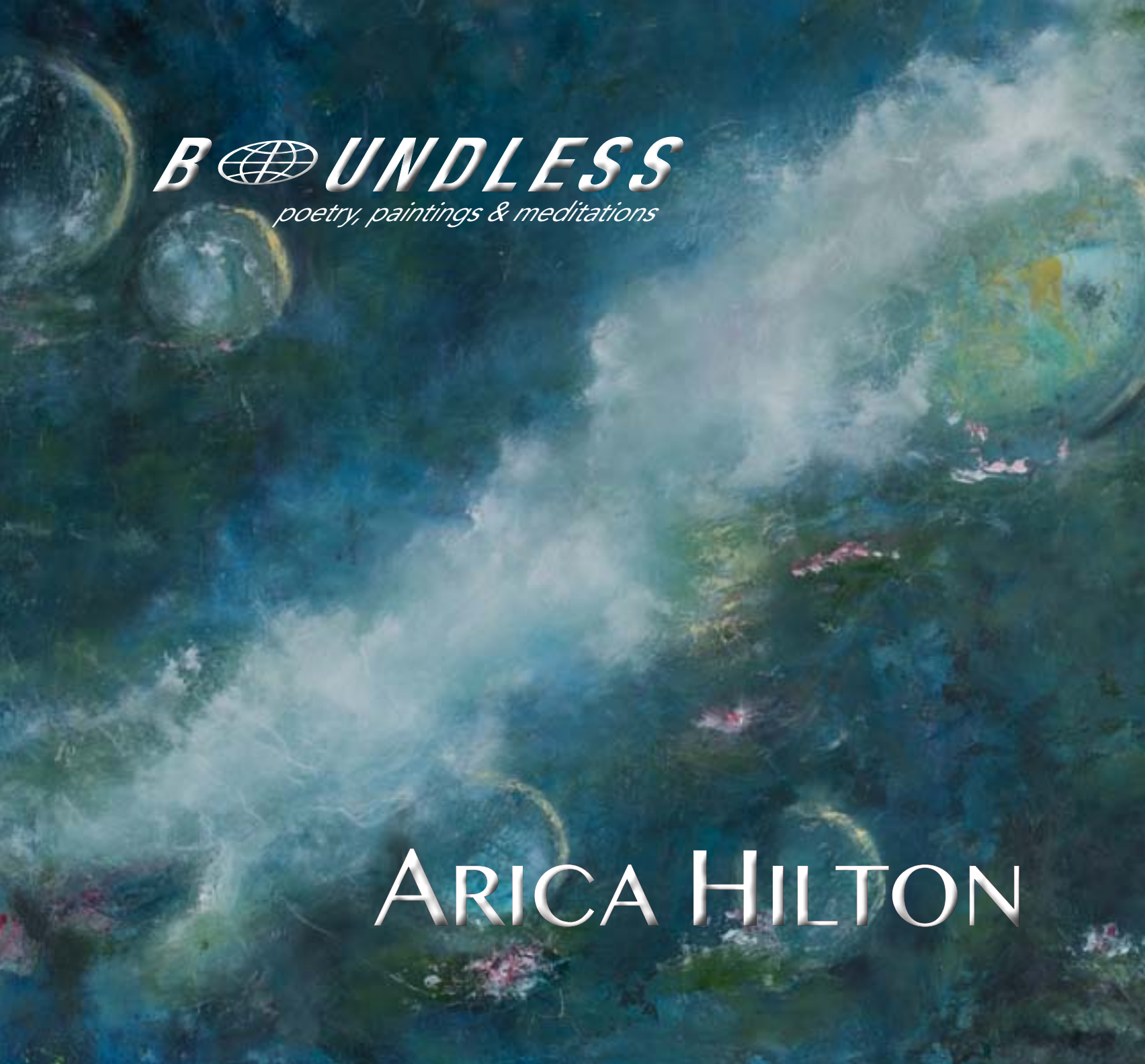

BOUNDLESS

poetry, paintings & meditations

ARICA HILTON

WHATEVER IT IS THAT BINDS A HAND TO A HEART

OR A SOUL TO A DREAM,

ETERNALLY BINDS A BIRD TO A ROOT,

BLOSSOMING....

FROM THE FOOT OF A STEM

TO THE FACE OF A CLOUD,

INFINITY HAS BOUNDS ONLY TO INFINITY.

A DREAM IS A DREAM

ONLY WHEN UNFULFILLED....

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Front & Back Cover: Arica Hilton, *WATER WORLDS,* oil on canvas (page 38-39)

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BOUNDLESS

BY ARICA HILTON

When I was a young girl, I discovered a poem by Chilean poet, Pablo Neruda, that touched me so deeply that it gave birth to the passionate pursuit of the meaning of my life. It's interesting how in that magic instant one can change course and chart a new path without even realizing it. It began with travel. Not travel in the touristy sort of way. But travel, during the course of business, such as my trips to Japan. When business was done, I would slip away and take the Shinkansen (bullet train) by myself from Tokyo to Kyoto to visit the numerous temples and gardens. I reveled in this new world as I learned about a new people and their cultures. It was like taking an enrichment course.

As much as I loved travel and expanding my world, it was a lonely time for me. I was still young and had not yet settled into my skin, as they say. I had never quite felt rooted anywhere. Born in another country and coming to America at the age of six, I didn't even speak the language. I learned English after many months but that feeling of displacement had never really left me.

A few years later, I was invited on a trek to the "Top of the World" by a Tibetan monk who became a lifelong friend. Geshe Lobsang Yonten took me on a journey that continued my enrichment in spiritual studies. I was fascinated by the various philosophies and religions that human beings had created. We traveled to the Indian Himalayas and visited numerous Tibetan Buddhist monasteries. Weeks later, we eventually ended up in Dharamsala, where upon meeting the Dalai Lama, I felt my heart chakra had opened. I was in a state of love for weeks afterwards. Those were exciting days. The only time I could shake that feeling of loneliness was when I was in that magical, mystical feeling of being in love.

Travel adventures are the greatest education, but no matter where I went, I was still with me. I could not lose myself or find myself, unless I stayed in that place of love. What was I looking for? I loved being in sacred places and meeting sacred people. But what comprised sacredness? Was it someone else's designation of what was truly "sacred?" I respected other's beliefs, but I realized that their beliefs did not necessarily resonate with me, although I would appropriate what I felt applied to my life. Years later, a friend told me that I was a "Synchretist," an amalgamation of different schools of thought, culture or religion. I tried to live by the best of all I had learned from the teachers in my life.

And I found myself turning always to poetry. Like a lover pursues the beloved, Poetry pursued me. It was my "Herzblut" as they say in German, my lifeblood, my passion. Reading that first poem by Neruda *"Your breast is enough for my heart and my wings for your freedom. What was sleeping above your soul will rise out of my mouth to heaven"* had transported me. And then I discovered Rilke *"The purpose of life is to be defeated by greater and greater things,"* and 13th century Sufi mystic poet/philospher, Rumi, *"This Being Human is a Guest House."* And then Ibn 'Arabi, the 12th century Sufi poet/philosopher born in Spain came to me. When you register on Facebook, they ask what is your religion? My answer was, *"Love, Peace and Freedom."* Later I discovered a line written by Ibn 'Arabi, *"Love is my religion."* I had found my companions in life. Or they found me.

Years later, I met my father for the first time. It was an unfamiliar experience, rather unexpected, so I asked him if he could tell me about the family that I did not grow up with. I wanted to learn about my roots. Born in Turkey, but raised in America, I had no idea where I really came from. Who was I? Three years later, my father brought me a gift, my genealogical chart. It was a fascinating compilation of characters reaching all the way back to Noah and Adam! And it was only the male line! I took the chart to a professor at University of Chicago to translate some of the names. He was quite impressed with my ancestry, many of whom were poets and philosophers. And who was on that list? None other than Muhiddin Ibn 'Arabi!

That was another step to put my life into perspective. With the reassurance that my DNA was in action, one poem led to another until I was ready for my words to be visually defined. And so the paintings began to unfold. As I explored the visual poetry, I felt I needed to go deeper into the realm of the creation. Isn't that what religions strive for? I discovered mathematics and physics, quantum mechanics, string theory. All those stars I used to talk to as a child, I realized were nothing more than another extension of humanity. I learned that all the elements in our bloodstream are the same elements that comprise a star. And what my ancestor Ibn 'Arabi, Rumi and all the mystical poets wrote about was that interconnection of the human being with the universe. And that is what I had been searching for my entire life. That we are the same as a star. How beautful is that?

Arica Hilton

FLUIDE COMME LE BONHEUR PAR ARICA HILTON

FOREWARD **PICK KEOBANDITH PH.D**

In reading Arica Hilton's poetry or discovering her paintings, the spectator experiences her deep exploration of beauty that leads us to pure and simple happiness.

From lessons on darkness, she takes us on a journey that calls us to life through mysterious paradises where heaven and earth mingle and we lose the limits of our human spaces. Some of her canvases show blazing skies untouched by storms, reminding us of Turner whom the artist admires. But she is not his disciple. She follows her own interior path with a romantic soul and broad culture.

From sunny landscapes, Hilton takes us to expanses of turquoise and grey-blue waters. In these works, she plays at confusing our thoughts and imagination. She composes aquatic canvases where the fluid texture of her paint evokes notes like the peaceful rhythm of incoming waves on a Mediterranean beach, whereas she may be referring to the shores of the Bosporus or crossing a Michigan Lake.

It is her quest for happiness through lunar-solar landscapes that make us understand that those moments of real pleasure and well-being are fleeting. She separates the azure from darkness and dreams of sparkling stars. In her work, everything is calm and of a quiet strength, just like Hilton herself, a beautiful and graceful woman with a powerful will to explore the intricasies of life.

Pick Keobandith PhD
Directrice Qu Art SA
Lisboa, 9 mai 2014

translation from French to English
Louisa Burnett-Hall

"And still, after all this time,
the Sun has never said to the Earth,
"You owe me."
Look what happens with a love like that.
It lights up the sky."
– Hafez (14th century)

In your light I learn how to love.

In your beauty, how to make poems.

You dance inside my chest where no one sees you,

but sometimes...I do....

and that sight

becomes this art.

— Rumi (13 century)

LET ME TELL YOU ABOUT WINDS

Let me tell you about winds.
They can go anywhere.
They need no visa to enter your hair
or a country drawn
by a cartographer's pen.

They can carry things.

They can carry a grain of sand
in multiples across a century,
or petals of a ripened rose
ready to leave its roots
and travel into the air toward its dying.

They can spread the waves
into a tide from the ocean floor,
or spread your warmth in whispers
across my face.

They can stir trees into ballet
or sweep your song
into the nations of my heart.

Let me tell you about winds.

They whistled rumours
of your love to eternity.
Time, sand, sky...
All that never ends.
They carried you to me
and gave me breath
to carry on.

—ah

I WANT TO LAY MY MIND ON A BED OF SILENCE

I want to lay my mind on a bed of silence
Resting on a featherpillow of solitude
No voices, sounds to invade my thoughts
Just serenity like a flowing brook
Sailing deep into the harbors of my soul.

I want to quench my thirst in just
a thimbleful of silence
And drink the music of
the soundless sunlight
And fashion the poetry of my thoughts
In silent scribblings upon my sheet.

I want to rest my eyes on a
velvet screen of silence
Let rivers run through
the cinders of my mind
Washing in stillness
of a sapphire pool
As Quiet
caresses the light
Streaming lyrics
through the
dominions of my dreams.

–ah

This is how I would die

into the love I have for you:

as pieces of cloud dissolve in sunlight.

—Rumi (13th century)

ODES TO THE BIRDS OF THE NIGHT

Today, my odes to the birds of the night are past.
A drowsy numbness no longer dulls my sense.
The hemlock has honeyed into
harmony stirring in a cup.

I feel a skylark in the eyes of your sky
Blue reigns through the haze again,
The temple strides the fork in the road
Asking the will of the way.

Oh! I want to feel the arrows of your rays
transmuting the air into an aria of winged saints,
To feel the brush of your breeze
turning a stone into velvet.

I want to live in your Garden
full of knowledge most refuse to pick
because they are afraid to taste the pomegranate
or a seed they fear will grow.

Oh yes, I have tasted your fruit
And it is fine,
Sweet, tender meat,
Moist, divine.

Breathe your warmth into my breast
And I will rise like wheat
To meet your fidelity.
I will be a willow to passing storms,
Real or imaginary,
Your whisper, my shield.

I will love love as you love love,
Delve into the treasury of captured dreams.
The sun removes the veil of the moon,
You guide my words on a chariot of stars
To the nave of your fragrant ripening.

Dear God,
I will sing odes to Your wings.

—*ah*

THIS IS HOW I FELT THE FIRST TIME I MET YOU

Inside dreams,
In this world,
Treading life
between Radiance and Mystery,
A flame bursts into a black hole.

A sunstorm of passion,
A moonlight of madness
Whips the clouds into drunkenness
Until they can no longer hold liquid
within their threads.

They hang heavy
like a cheese cloth full,
delivering opaque juices
into a sizzling storm.

You,
lapping it up,

I,
waiting for your waves
To etch my perfection.

—ah

THOUGHTS

A capsule containing thoughts
remotely wrapped in layers,
brick-stalled desires,
breaks in the shadows of silence.

For one whose breath moves in solitary whispers,
a glance moves the heart
in a tidal wave of skin
stirring, hot oil,
dancing in the brush of a hand.

What is desire in the face of a body
Swirling,
a virtuosity of color
in a black and white landscape,
a dance too sonorous for solo exhibition.

An aria of roses unfolds its silence
to reveal confectioneries.

A four leaf clover nestles in a rainbow of thress.

There is acorner of a room that shileds my thoughts from detection.

There is a corner of a soul that waits for my reflection.

—ah

YOUR MYSTERY

You dwell in mystery
like echoes of night.
Hidden treasures veiled
unspoken in light.

I see through your mist
with eyes of kohl.
I see into the labyrinth
of your soul.

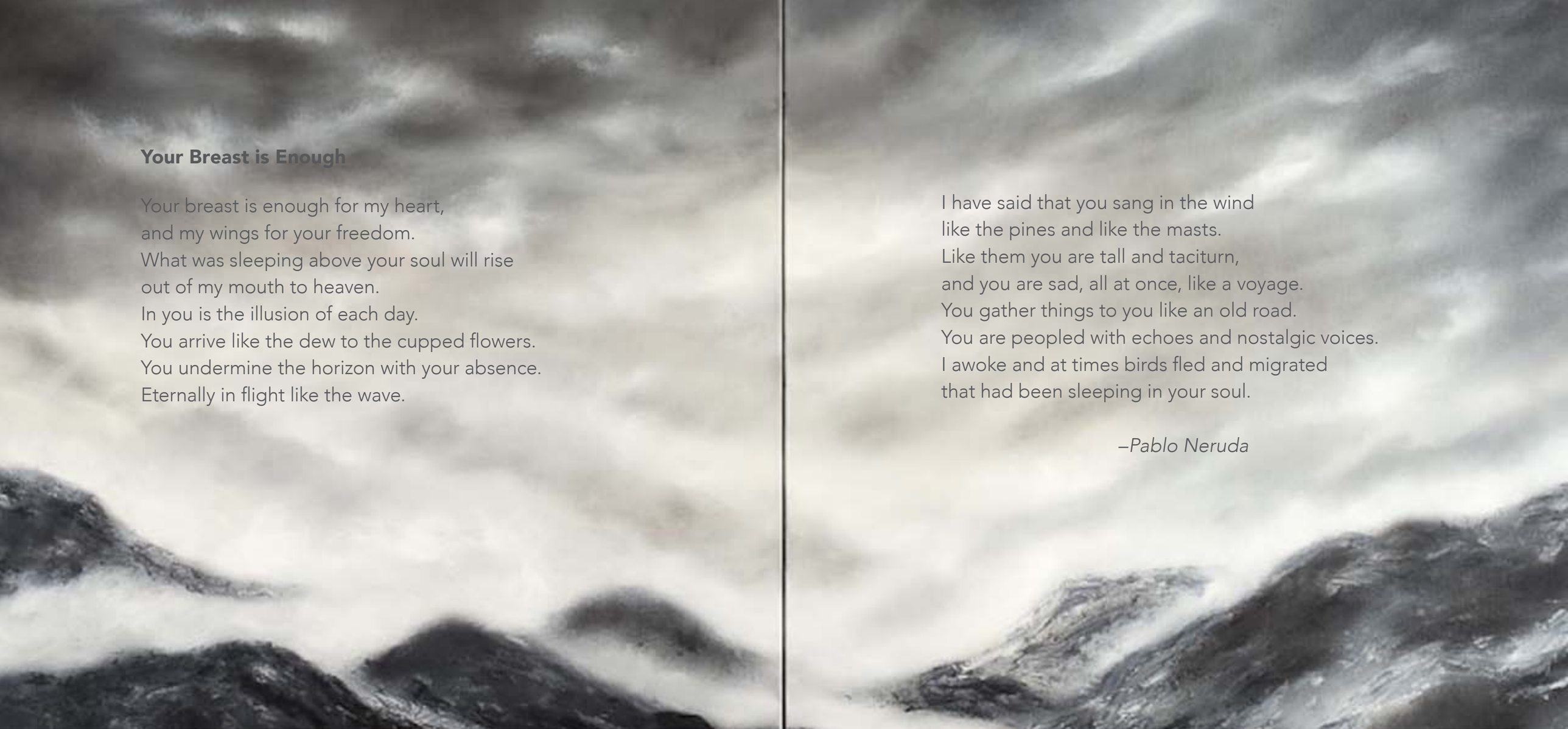
Your mystery contains
a clue or two
of the Oceans of Truth
that reside in you.

Of your glorious battles
fought for right,
of forlorn victories
in no one's sight.

Your valiant heart
goes not unseen.
These eyes record
your courageous lean.

Have faith, brave heart
the winds will stream
less mighty, more balmy
like a midnight dream.

—ah



Your Breast is Enough

Your breast is enough for my heart,
and my wings for your freedom.
What was sleeping above your soul will rise
out of my mouth to heaven.
In you is the illusion of each day.
You arrive like the dew to the cupped flowers.
You undermine the horizon with your absence.
Eternally in flight like the wave.

I have said that you sang in the wind
like the pines and like the masts.
Like them you are tall and taciturn,
and you are sad, all at once, like a voyage.
You gather things to you like an old road.
You are peopled with echoes and nostalgic voices.
I awoke and at times birds fled and migrated
that had been sleeping in your soul.

–Pablo Neruda

I HEARD AN OAK TREE

And it was in a garden I heard that sound,
A deep groan,
like a bass note
searching for the root.

I heard a collision, like hands
pushing aside dirt,
clearing a path for light
to pour into the center of the earth.

I heard a chord
echoing rumours of sunsets
kissing a canopy of trees
And strains of rain streaming life into your limbs.

I heard the Knowing that we belong to Sameness
To earth, to sun, to stars,
to mountains, oceans, trees….
Elements forming you, forming me.

With the window open
(the way you like to sleep)
I heard an oak tree
lamenting in the breeze,

"I was here before you,
rooted,
like you,
reaching,
like you."

—ak

"Don't be satisfied with stories,

how things have gone with others.

Unfold your own myth."

— Rumi (13th Century)

ONE DAY LIKE **RAIN**

Tender words we spoke
to one another
are sealed
in the secret vaults of heaven.

One day like rain,
they will fall to earth
and grow green
all over the world.

—*Rumi (13th Century)*

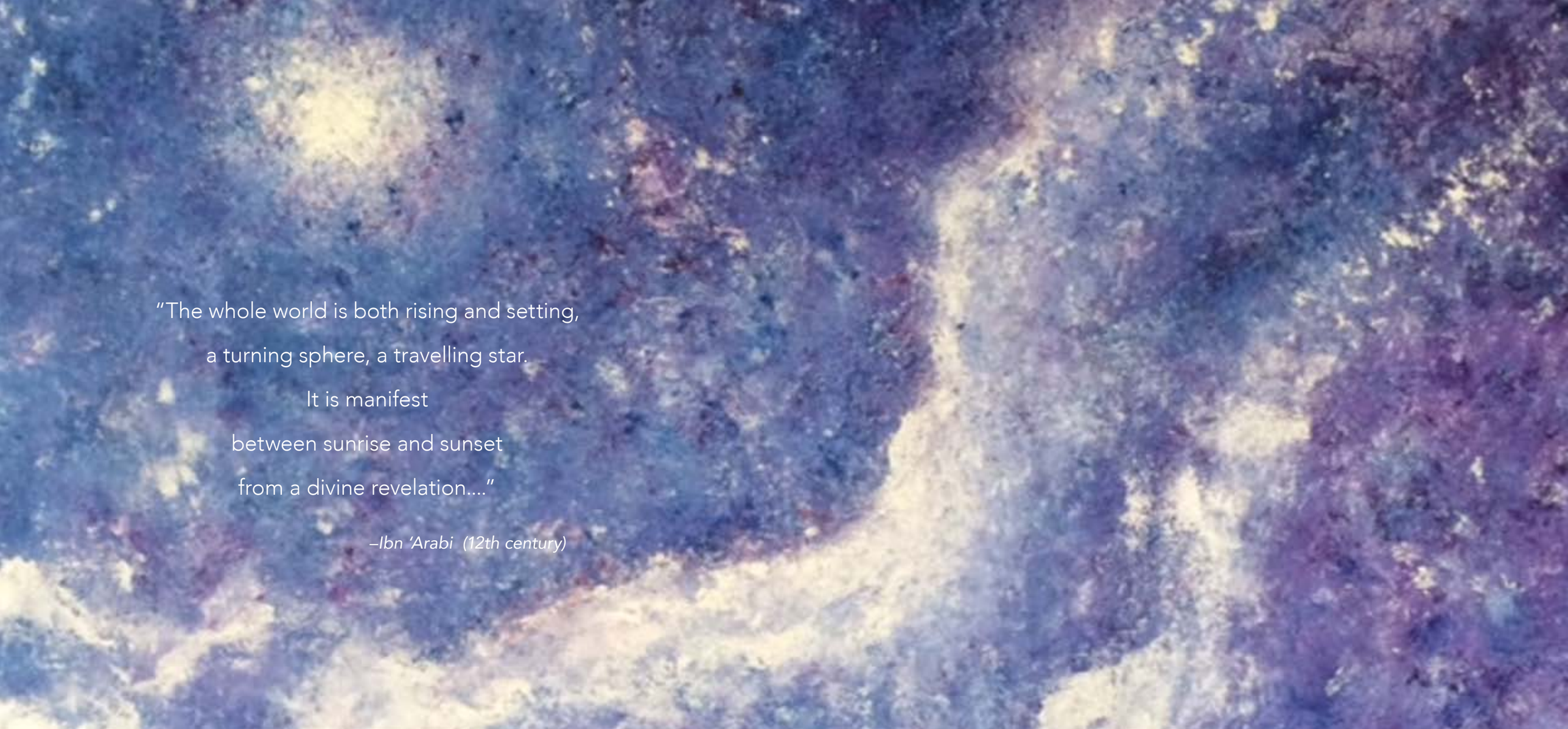
He who is born in imagination
discovers the latent forces of Nature...
Besides the stars that are established
there is yet another
--Imagination--
that begets a new star
and a new heaven.
-Paracelsus (16th century)

I flow like water.....
If in every breath I could feel water,
taste water
see water,
hear water,
BE water....
then I can surrender
to being.....
just being.....ME...
—ah

My life is not this steeply sloping hour,
In which you see me hurrying.
Much stands behind me; I stand before it like a tree;
I am only on one of my many mouths,
and at that, the one that will be still the soonest.

I am the rest between two notes,
Which are somehow always in discord
Because Death's note wants to climb over—
But in the dark interval, reconciled,
They stay there trembling.
And the song goes on, beautiful.

–Rainer Maria Rilke



"The whole world is both rising and setting,
a turning sphere, a travelling star.
It is manifest
between sunrise and sunset
from a divine revelation...."

–Ibn 'Arabi (12th century)

"From my insufficiency to my perfection, and from my deviation to my equilibrium

From my sublimity to my beauty, and from my splendor to my majesty

From my scattering to my gathering, and from my rejection to my communion

From my baseness to my preciousness, and from my stones to my pearls

From my rising to my setting, and from my days to my nights

From my luminosity to my darkness, and from my guidance to my straying

From my perigee to my apogee, and from the base of my lance to its tip

From my waxing to my waning, and from the void of my moon to its crescent

From my pursuit to my flight, and from my steed to my gazelle

From my breeze to my boughs, and from my boughs to my shade

From my shade to my delight, and from my delight to my torment

From my torment to my likeness, and from my likeness to my impossibility

From my impossibility to my validity, and from my validity to my deficiency.

I am no one in existence but myself,"

– Ibn Arabi (12 century)

Where stars are born.....

"I was wedded to all the stars of the sky.
There was not a single star left, and I married
every one of them with great spiritual pleasure.
Then I married the moon."

–Ibn 'Arabi (12th century)

SWAN **NEBULA**

A nebula is an interstellar cloud of dust and gases where stars are born. All stars began their lives as a nebula. As a star dies it returns its material to the cosmos as another nebula. It is through this release of matter that the universe is provided with all the elements heavier than hydrogen and helium. This includes all the material that forms the Earth and everything on it, including humans. The oxygen we breathe was formed in the hearts of giant stars and the iron in our bloodstream was formed in the final days of a massive star's existence before it ripped itself to pieces as a supernova.

It is from this that we get the saying that we are all made of stardust....

I, simply walk up the sky,
like a star,
waiting to be named
by my discoverer...

SUNSET

Slowly the west reaches for clothes of new colours
which it passes to a row of ancient trees.
You look, and soon these two worlds both leave you,
one part climbs toward heaven, one sinks to earth,

leaving you, not really belonging to either,
not so helplessly dark as that house that is silent,
not so unswervingly given to the eternal as that thing
that turns to a star each night and climbs —

leaving you (it is impossible to untangle the threads)
your own life, timid and standing high and growing,
so that, sometimes blocked in, sometimes reaching out,
one moment your life is a stone in you, and the next, a star.

–Rainer Maria Rilke

A HUNTER

A hunter with a big net catches stars
falling from the Milky Way.
He keeps them in a basket full of
moons
circling love like the seasons,

As You,
weave the threads of sunrise
like a waking wave of kisses,
skipping the stones of my heart
rippling through my flesh
as only the horns of heaven can.

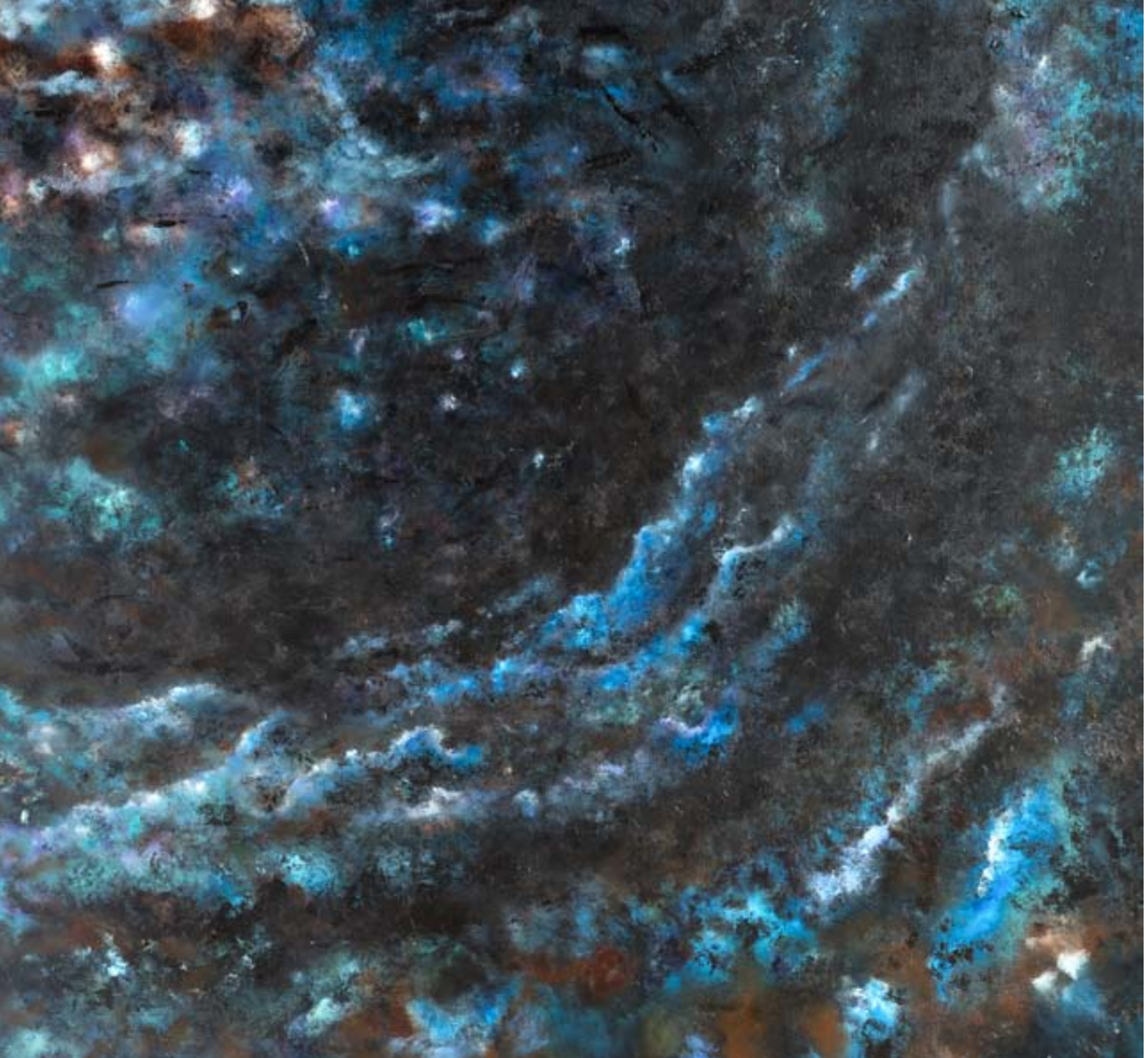
You, outlined in fireflies,
watch the moon filling fulfilling,
strumming the sun into prose.

A man flies into an ocean, feet first,
his wings melt into fins,
neck stretching skyward,
like a swan's,
in truth, certainly, most veritable
as above, as below.

I can't decide if the Emerald Tablet is
his ticket to transformation,
or just the whim of a mythic man
who discovered his reflection
in Orion.

I,
simply walk up the sky
like a star,
Waiting to be named
by my discoverer.

—ah



HIEROGLYPH

If reduced to a hieroglyph
How would someone translate me
A thousand years from now?

Yes, reduced,
like a sauce in a very expensive French restaurant.
They might say, "Oui, she is a reduction
Of daughter, mother, lover,
sister, partner, friend."

"She simmered into them
year after year."

Or they might say,
"After so much work
So much training
She hit the target with her arrow.
She swam faster than a dolphin.
And ran across the finish line…
.....Like a star.

She became a hero
Not because she wanted to be
.....She had no choice."

They might ask,
"Was her blood, her flesh, bones and muscle,
formed by a cloud of dust and gases?
Did her strength spring forth
in the final days of a massive star's existence
before it ripped itself to pieces
…..like a Supernova?

"Her light outshines the galaxies
She radiates more energy than the sun.
And People gather to her.
She lifts and guides,
sometimes falls."

If someone asks you, where did she come from?
Answer them,
"She came from the stars.
A thousand years from now,
That's where she will be."

—ah

I am a seagull
flying through illumination,
a reflection
pouring into waves.

I am a boat
navigating breath,
the wind
spiriting through you.

I am an angel at ease...

—ah

Arica Hilton was born on the Mediterranean coast of Turkey. As a young girl, she studied architecture and design and has worked as a gallerist, interior designer, poet and artist since 1985. Whether it is visual art through paintings or the poetic expressions of language and music, every aspect of Arica's life is geared towards one form of art melding into another.

Her collaborations include working with Italian artist, Marco Nereo Rotelli in sound and light installations at Northwestern University in Evanston, IL and the FIELD MUSEUM OF NATURAL HISTORY in Chicago. Hilton not only curated the poets and poetry, but also wrote the finale poem "Bring In the Fruit" for DIVINA NATURA, FIELD OF LIGHT inspired by Dante Alighieri's INFERNO.

Hilton also created a monumental painting for actress Nora Dunn's one woman play, MYTHICAL PROPORTIONS, at Theater Wit in Chicago. Her ten foot painting, UNIVERSE, *LIFE UNLIMITED*, became, as Ms. Dunn stated, "a character in my play."

Hilton lives and works in Chicago. Until recently, she was the president of the board of the Poetry Center of Chicago and was voted one of the LIT 50: Who Really Books in Chicago 2011 by New City. Her works have been seen in Fine Art Magazine, Michigan Avenue Magazine, Huffington Post, Astronomy Magazine, Art World News, The Examiner, Chicago Tribune, Chicago Sun Times.

Her works are in collections throughout the United States, Europe and Asia.